

Responsible Digital Youth Initiative

Developing Responsible Digital Citizens and Independent Thinkers for Bangladesh

Executive Summary

Bangladesh's secondary students are growing up in a digital environment they were never formally taught to navigate. Social media algorithms, AI tools, and information ecosystems are shaping how young people think, learn, and make decisions — at a pace that school curricula have not yet matched.

The **Responsible Digital Youth Initiative** offers a structured, school-based response. Through a focused 60-minute workshop for Classes 9–12, students develop digital citizenship and responsible AI literacy as integrated, practical competencies. This is not a digital safety programme. It is a critical thinking and **future-readiness initiative**.

We invite schools to join a free pilot that equips students, supports teachers, and contributes to building a stronger foundation for responsible digital development in Bangladesh.

Theory of Change

If students understand how technology shapes attention, information, and decision-making, and develop critical thinking and digital citizenship skills, they will use digital technologies and AI responsibly, make **independent judgments**, and become more resilient contributors to Bangladesh's future.

Why this Intervention?

Literature Review

Smartphone & Social Media Trends: Research confirms that the vast majority of rural and urban youth spend time on social media platforms (Facebook, TikTok) for entertainment rather than study, leading to significant distraction (Wiley, 2025).

BYLC News Consumption Survey: Highlights that 70-80% of youth rely on social media for news, leaving them exposed to misinformation without critical evaluation training (Dhaka Tribune, 2025).

EdTech Hub / UNDP Report: Confirms that AI tool adoption is already underway among Bangladeshi university-bound students, yet critical ethical-guidance infrastructure remains missing (EdTech Hub, 2025).

Social media engagement, smartphone dependence, and early AI-use are already widespread among Bangladeshi adolescents, but structured digital-ethics education is weak in the formal secondary curriculum (Dhaka Tribune, 2025). **Grade 09–12 is a strategic window** because:

1. Students are **cognitively and socially mature** enough to grasp ethical concepts
2. They are **transitioning to higher education or the workforce**

UNESCO “Digital Kids Asia-Pacific” Framework, World Bank Employability Studies, UNDP reports all justify a structured intervention in the digital ethics for innovation and workforce readiness. Our intervention initiative aims to study that particular area in Bangladesh context.

Focused Group Discussion

Our conversations with students revealed a concerning reality: most spend a significant portion of their **online time consuming reels and entertainment content**, many are **not confident in distinguishing between true and false information online**, and when **faced with digital challenges, they often rely on trial-and-error, friends, or YouTube** rather than trusted adult guidance.

Many students—**particularly girls**—have **already experienced offensive messages or upsetting online interactions** and have had to manage these situations on their own. These findings highlight that students are navigating a complex digital world largely without the knowledge, skills, and support needed to do so safely and responsibly.

This creates a clear opportunity for educational institutes to equip students with essential digital citizenship, critical thinking, and online safety skills through structured, evidence-based interventions delivered by external specialists.

Our Intervention Aims to Connect

Across five interconnected learning areas, students build the practical skills and awareness to navigate digital life more confidently and responsibly:

- **Digital citizenship** — understanding rights, responsibilities, and ethical behavior online
- **Attention and well-being** — recognizing how platforms compete for attention and how to regain control
- **Information verification** — using structured frameworks (SIFT) to evaluate online content before acting
- **Responsible AI literacy** — knowing when to trust, question, and remain independent of AI tools
- **Critical and independent thinking** — the integrating skill that connects all five learning areas

Programme Structure

The initiative is delivered as a single, well-sequenced 60-minute workshop. Sessions follow a clear pedagogical arc designed to build from awareness to action:

#	Topic	What Students Explore	Core Skill
1	Digital Well-being & Attention	Screen time, algorithmic feeds, and doomscrolling	<i>Attention literacy</i>
2	Navigating Information	Misinformation, deepfakes, and the SIFT verification framework	<i>Information literacy</i>
3	Online Behavior & Safety	Cyberbullying, digital empathy, phishing and online scams	<i>Ethical behavior</i>
4	Artificial Intelligence & Human Judgment	AI capabilities, hallucinations, bias, and over-dependence risks	<i>Responsible AI literacy</i>
5	Critical Thinking & Independent Judgment	Applying critical thinking as the integrating life skill	<i>Digital citizenship</i>

A single well-facilitated session will not transform behaviour overnight. But it can shift awareness, introduce practical tools, and plant the foundation for more responsible digital citizenship.